Aquifer Open Study Notes

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Habakkuk

Habakkuk 1:1

The word message (or oracle) shows the book as God's revelation through his prophet (compare Nahum 1:1; Malachi 1:1).

Habakkuk 1:2

I call for help but You do not hear: The call and answer theme in Scripture often shows the speaker's trust in God as a refuge or guide (see Psalm 102:1–2). It also indicates a close relationship between the believer and God (Psalm 145:18; Isaiah 65:24).

Habakkuk 1:2–4

To Habakkuk, God seemed unconcerned about the evil spread throughout society in Judah (Habakkuk 1:3–4). God also seemed silent when Habakkuk complained about this evil (1:2).

Habakkuk 1:3

In Habakkuk's time, destruction and violence were widespread in Judean society (see Habakkuk Book Introduction, "Setting").

Habakkuk 1:4

Habakkuk shares his worry about the injustice and wrongdoing he observed everywhere (see Habakkuk 1:12–13; 2:4, 9), even in the courts, where the law failed to uphold justice.

Habakkuk 1:5

Look ... observe: Two different Hebrew verbs are also translated as see and tolerate in Habakkuk 1:3. This creates a literary connection between Habakkuk's questions in Habakkuk 1:3 and God's reply in 1:5–11.

Habakkuk 1:5–11

God's answer to Habakkuk's question is surprising. God would send a violent group (the Babylonians) to address the violence in Judah. The Babylonian army, well-trained and experienced in battle, was unstoppable.

Habakkuk 1:7

from themselves: The Babylonians offered no relief from injustice. They followed their own laws, which confused the prophet about why God chose them to punish Judah.

Habakkuk 1:8

The vivid images of cheetahs, wolves, and eagles show how fast and violent the Babylonian attacks against Judah were. These animals also show that the Babylonians hunted their enemies like prey (see Jeremiah 4:13; 48:40; 49:22).

Habakkuk 1:9

The Babylonians took many people from Judah into exile between 605 and 586 BC (see Daniel 1:1–3).

Habakkuk 1:10

In the ancient Near East, armies often attacked cities by piling up earth to make ramps against city walls. This battle method is described in several places in the Bible (for example, 2 Kings 19:32; Nahum 2:1).

Habakkuk 1:11

their own strength is their god: The Babylonians worshiped many false gods. They proudly relied on their military power as another idol.

Habakkuk 1:12

- Despite his confusion, Habakkuk did not abandon God. By saying my God, my Holy One, he showed his commitment to the Lord before asking important questions about what God had revealed to him.
- In light of God's character and covenant with Israel, Habakkuk was sure that God would not destroy his people.
- to execute judgment: Compare Hebrews 12:5–11.
- O Rock: This is a common image of God's faithfulness and strength (see Deuteronomy 32:15; 1 Samuel 2:2; Psalm 18:2; 1 Corinthians 10:4; 1 Peter 2:6–8).

Habakkuk 1:12–2.1

Habakkuk struggled to understand how God's answer in Habakkuk 1:5–11 fit with God's character. How could a holy and just God punish Judah using a people more unrighteous than they were?

Habakkuk 1:14–15

fish ... hook ... dragnet: Habakkuk describes the Babylonians as fishermen who pull conquered peoples in like fish, showing how easily they captured their enemies.

Habakkuk 1:16

See study note on Habakkuk 1:11; compare 1 John 5:21.

Habakkuk 2:1

I will stand at my guard post: Like a sentinel on duty (a guard who watches for danger), Habakkuk waited with care and expectation to see how the Lord would answer his complaint. He was ready to listen, even if the Lord corrected him (see also 2 Samuel 18:24–28; 2 Kings 9:17–20; Ezekiel 33:2–6).

Habakkuk 2:2

God tells the prophet to write the vision clearly so people can understand, keep, and share it with others.

Habakkuk 2:2–5

Habakkuk's mission was to tell people that God's justice may seem slow, but it will definitely come.

Habakkuk 2:2–20

God answers Habakkuk's second complaint (Habakkuk 1:12–2:1) but does not explain why he chose the Babylonians. Instead, he assures Habakkuk that he will punish all violence and injustice.

Habakkuk 2:3

it will surely come: At a future time known only to the Lord, he will step into earth's history and bring it to a proper end. He will support the righteous and judge the wicked. God's people must wait patiently, knowing that the divine plan is on schedule (see Hebrews 10:35–38).

Habakkuk 2:4

- God knows when proud people live only for themselves. Their dishonest lives show that they are not righteous. They refuse God's instruction and choose what seems right to them (Proverbs 12:15; 21:8, 29; 29:27). In contrast, the righteous stand in the right relationship with God. They accept God's righteous standards and live them out in their daily lives.
- faith: Hebrew 'emunah. This word translates the Hebrew 'emunah ("steadfastness, trust"). In Genesis, the same Hebrew root ('mn) describes Abram's trust in God (Genesis 15:6). God transforms how people think and choose when they trust him so they can follow God's holy standards faithfully. See also Romans 1:16–17; Galatians 3:11; Hebrews 10:37–39.

Habakkuk 2:6–8

- In the first of Habakkuk's taunt songs, he condemns the Babylonians for plundering other nations.
- him who amasses what is not his and makes himself rich with many loans: The image compares the Babylonians to creditors (people who lend money) who demand harsh repayment. Their oppression causes those they exploit to rise up against them. Greed can damage the spiritual life of both individuals and nations (Luke 12:15; Ephesians 5:3).

Habakkuk 2:6–20

Five taunt songs describe God's future judgment on the Babylonians and others who act violently and unjustly (Habakkuk 2:6–8, 9–11, 12–14, 15–17, 18–20). God lets them bring about their own destruction. Those who suffer will repeat these taunts when the wicked face judgment (see Habakkuk 1:14–17). Each taunt includes:

- a statement of sorrow,
- a judgment, and
- the reason for God's judgment.

Habakkuk 2:9–11

In the second taunt song, the Babylonians face condemnation for their dishonest actions. They used deceit to gain resources for building large houses, which cost them their lives.

Habakkuk 2:12–14

- In the third taunt song, the Babylonians face condemnation for their murder and corruption, which they used to gain wealth and build their cities. God will turn their apparent gain into a total loss.
- Earth will be filled: Unlike violence and stolen wealth, the awareness of the Lord's glory will spread as widely as water in the ocean (Isaiah 11:9).

Habakkuk 2:15–17

In the fourth taunt song, the Babylonians face condemnation for their shameful acts against people, animals, and the environment. They are like a man who pretends to be friendly but, after getting his neighbors drunk, takes everything from them. However, the Babylonians will face disgrace after drinking from the cup of the Lord's judgment (see Jeremiah 25:15–17; compare John 18:11).

Habakkuk 2:18–20

In the fifth taunt song, the Babylonians face criticism for worshiping idols. Whether people carve or cast idols, they cannot save or teach their worshipers (Isaiah 42:17). Only the Lord truly deserves worship (Habakkuk 2:20; Exodus 20:2–6; compare Ecclesiastes 5:1–2).

Habakkuk 2:20

The taunt songs end with a statement: The ruler of all nations is not a Babylonian idol but God who is holy (Habakkuk 2:18–20). Unlike the lifeless Babylonian idols, the living God resides in his holy temple. God's presence fills his heavenly sanctuary (Isaiah 6:1–5). During Habakkuk's time, God's presence filled the temple in Jerusalem (1 Kings 8:10–11). God controls all the earth and expects people to worship him in humble submission (Psalm 63:1–4; Jeremiah 10:1–10; Micah 7:16; Zechariah 2:13).

Habakkuk 3:1–19

Habakkuk's prophecy concludes with a prayer that has the style and language of a psalm (a song of prayer).

Habakkuk 3:2

- Habakkuk stands in awe before the LORD, who sits enthroned in his holy temple (Habakkuk 2:20).
- Because Judah will soon face punishment, Habakkuk prays to God. He asks the Lord, who acted powerfully to save Israel in the past, to act again. Habakkuk asks God to make his work of salvation known once more (see also Psalm 77).

Habakkuk 3:3

- Teman: This was one of Edom's main cities (see also Job 2:11; Jeremiah 49:7). The term could refer to the whole region of Edom where the city was located (compare Obadiah 1:9). Habakkuk's use of the term with Mount Paran suggests he meant the larger region.
- Holy One is an important title for God. It emphasizes that God is completely set apart and unlike anything or anyone else (Habakkuk 1:12; see also Exodus 15:11; 2 Kings 19:22; Psalm 77:13; Isaiah 6:3).
- Mount Paran: The region of Paran included the mountain range west and south of Edom and northeast of Mount Sinai, as well as a large desert area in the Sinai Peninsula.

Habakkuk 3:3–15

The prophet praises God's power to save. These two praise sections (Habakkuk 3:3–7 and 3:8–15) poetically reflect on Israel's exodus. Although Habakkuk focuses on God's redemption of his people, his imagery sometimes includes ideas from ancient Near Eastern stories about the gods. For example:

- pestilence and plague (Habakkuk 3:5)
- river and sea (Habakkuk 3:8)
- sun and moon (Habakkuk 3:11)

This imagery reminds Habakkuk's original audience that the Lord alone is the one true God who rules over all these things.

Habakkuk 3:4

like the sunlight: The Lord, who appeared on Mount Sinai and filled the southern land with glory, now fills the heavens with splendor.

Habakkuk 3:5

Habakkuk speaks of pestilence and plague as if they were people. He describes them as soldiers in God's army, carrying out God's purposes (see Deuteronomy 32:24; Exodus 7–12; Amos 4:10).

Habakkuk 3:5–6

God is the divine warrior who helps his people (see Habakkuk 3:8–15; see also Isaiah 63:1–6).

Habakkuk 3:7

Midian was in the southern area east of the Jordan River (see Genesis 36:35). The nation was terrified by God's powerful presence (Habakkuk 3:6).

Habakkuk 3:8

- angry at the rivers ... wrath against the streams: See Exodus 7:19–20; 14:15–31.
- chariots of salvation: This is an ironic reference to the Egyptian chariots that chased the Israelites when God helped them escape through the Red Sea (Exodus 14:9).

Habakkuk 3:8–15

The Lord acts as a divine warrior for his people, using his power to save them. This picture of God as a divine warrior appears in both the Old Testament and the New Testament.

In the Old Testament, it is seen in Israel's escape from Egypt and their journey to Mount Sinai (Exodus 15:1–18). It also appears as Israel approached the promised land from the south and during their early victories in the land (for example, Judges 5:4–5; Psalms 18:8–16; 77:16–20).

A key New Testament example of this theme appears in Revelation, where Christ comes as a warrior to defeat evil and bring final justice (Revelation 19:11–21).

Habakkuk 3:9–11

Only God controls the forces of the natural world.

Habakkuk 3:10

water: See study note on Habakkuk 3:8 and also Exodus 15:1–18.

Habakkuk 3:11

Sun and moon: See Joshua 10:12–13.

Habakkuk 3:15

Sea ... waters: The section ends the same way it started (Habakkuk 3:8).

Habakkuk 3:16

Even though realizing God's great power made Habakkuk tremble and lose strength, he would wait quietly for God's judgment (see Habakkuk 2:3).

Habakkuk 3:17–19

- After recounting God's powerful acts of redemption (Habakkuk 3:2–15) and pausing to reflect on them (3:16), Habakkuk reaffirms his trust in God as he ends his prayer.
- Though ... yet I will exult: Even if God never gives material blessings to his people again, he is still worthy of all their trust and praise. No matter what happens, the prophet could rejoice, knowing that the Lord is not only Israel's Redeemer but also the source of his own salvation.

Habakkuk 3:19

Habakkuk gained his strength from God, his Savior (Habakkuk 3:18). He compared his spiritual journey to a deer quickly climbing mountaintops and moving gracefully over them (see Psalm 18:32–33).